



Timer App: From Practice Project to Sustainable Product Strategy

A UX Research Case Study for a Solo Developer

How do you scale a passion project when you are the only employee?

The Accidental Success



Nov 2020

2020

The Founder: Philip, a self-taught developer using this as a practice project.

The Goal: **Learn to code.**
Zero marketing budget.

The Reality:

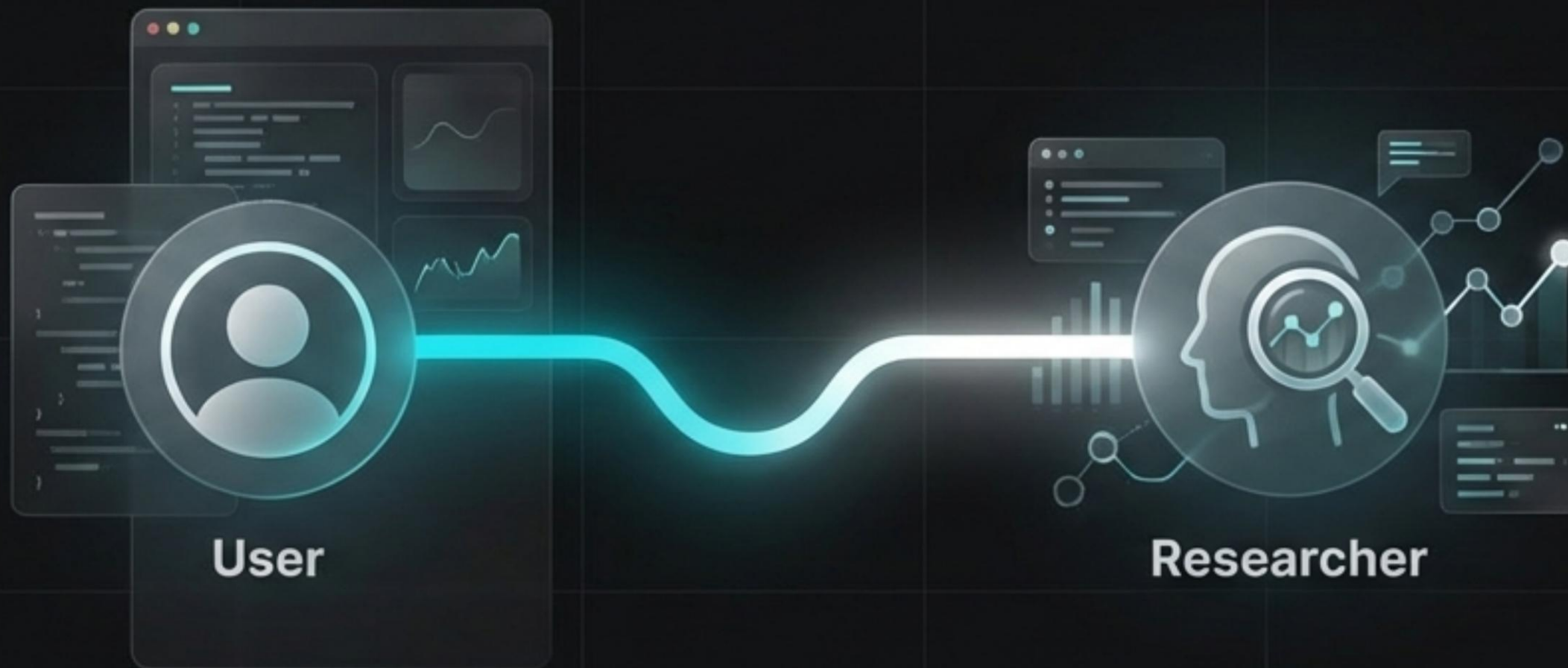
4,500 current active users. 
~3,500 paying subscribers. 

Today

The Tension:

Unexpected success brought retention anxiety. 

The User Becomes the Researcher



I didn't start as a consultant.
I started as a fan.

Context: Heavy user of
Timer App for deep work years.

Action: Reached out to Philip
to answer the critical
questions:
Why do they leave?
What should we build next?

A Desktop-First Audience

Top Territories: USA, India, China

The majority of the workflow happens on the desktop, not on the wrist.



53% Mac

MacBook Monitor

35%

iPhone

12%

iPad

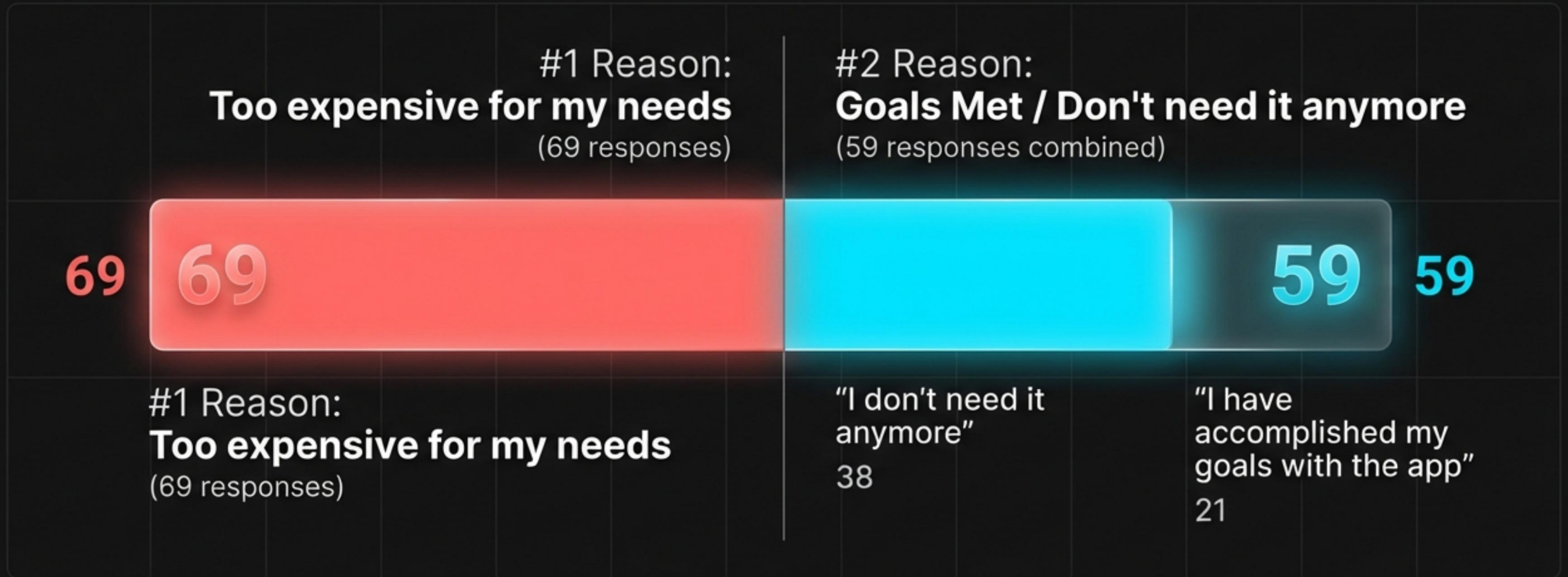
Exceptional Loyalty in the Long Tail



For a focus timer, retaining 11% of users after three years is exceptional. These users are deeply committed.

The Two Types of Churn

A significant portion of churn isn't dissatisfaction; it's completion.

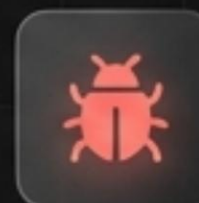


It's Not a Quality Problem

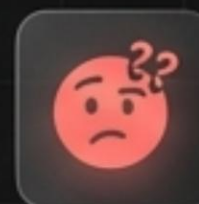
Product gaps and bugs are secondary. The core mechanics work beautifully. The friction is financial.



Primary Friction



Technical Problems: 10 responses



Difficult to Use: 3 responses

The Trap of the Loudest Voice

The community is screaming for an Apple Watch app.
It is the clear winner in the voting data.

Apple Watch app

💬 24



177
Votes

Time budget

I would like to set an amount of time I'm going to spend for priority projects this week + burn down chart

💬 14

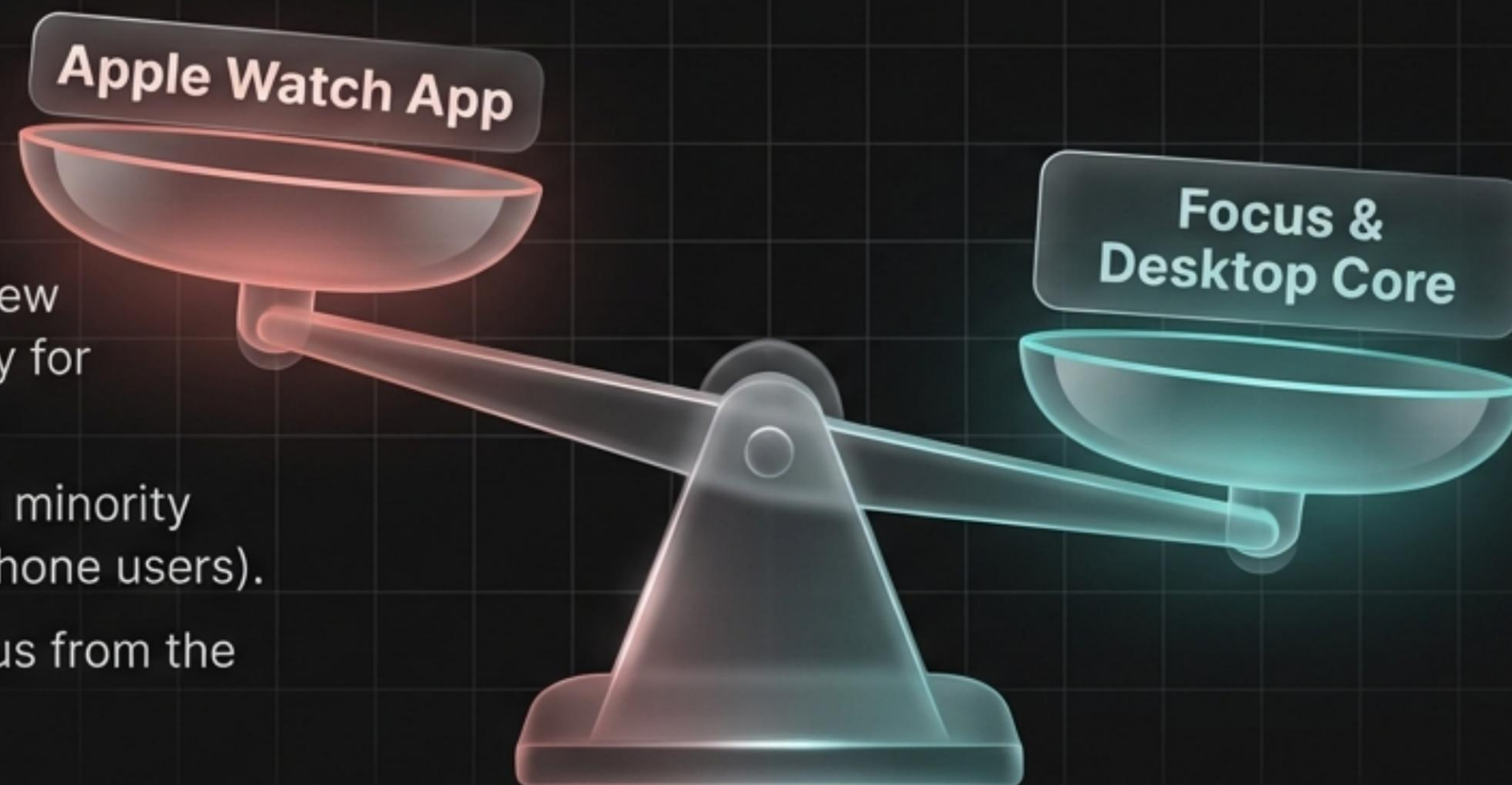


127
Votes

Why We Said No to the Apple Watch

Philip needs high-impact, low-maintenance wins.

- 1. **High Maintenance:** New codebase is too heavy for one person.
- 2. **Low Impact:** Serves a minority (subset of the 35% iPhone users).
- 3. **Distraction:** Pulls focus from the desktop core.



The Hidden Strategy: Native Task Management

By grouping task-related requests, a massive desire emerges:
Manage to-dos within* the flow, without complex 3rd party APIs.



Solving Price with Intimacy, Not Slashes

Base Price:

\$39.99/yr

**Small Family
Plan (Winner).**

3-5 Seats.
10-15% Discount.

**Large Team
Bundle.**

10 Seats.
Deep Discount.

Users want to share with a partner or close friends,
not buy an enterprise seat license.

The Solo Developer Roadmap

Philip is already implementing the to-do list, demonstrating a rapid response to insights.

- [x] 1. Build Native To-Do List (In Progress)
- [] 2. Launch Small Family Plans (3-5 seats)
- [-] 3. Deprioritize Apple Watch App

Research Limitations

- Simulated Data: Used forum votes and quit reasons, not live purchasing environments.
- Self-Selection Bias: Data reflects 'Super-fans' and 'Quitters'. The silent middle is underrepresented.
- Takeaway: We prioritized speed and direction over statistical perfection.



A person is sitting at a desk in a dimly lit room, working on a computer. The monitor displays a code editor with a file explorer on the left and code on the right. The person's hands are on a mechanical keyboard. A desk lamp is visible in the background.

Focus on What Is Sustainable

"The research didn't just tell Philip what to build. It gave him the confidence to ignore the noise and build what keeps his business—and his passion—alive."